



Discussion Guide: Diana Butler Bass

Jesus the Ingrate: The Subversive Politics of Gratitude

Reflect

- Diana introduces her talk by establishing giving thanks to God as a foundational practice in all religious traditions. What situations have led you to express thanks to God?
- Diana describes two systems of gratitude in the ancient world: the pyramid and the table. Do we still have these systems today? Where do you see them?
- Diana sees the two systems of gratitude described above playing out in the story of Zacchaeus ([Luke 19:1-10](#)). She concludes that when we fully participate in the table system, we will appear as an “ingrate” in the pyramid system. How does this change the way you understand the Zacchaeus story?

Respond

- Diana emphasizes that gratitude is not just an emotion, but a choice. Describe a circumstance in which you had to deliberately choose to be grateful for something. Why was this challenging? How did the choice of gratitude affect how you acted?
- Diana admits to having a difficult time accepting 1 Thess 5:18 that reads: “Give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.” What are issues/events in our world or in your life for which you find it hard to give thanks? Do you think 1 Thess 5:18 is meant to apply to these situations?
- The first line of the Ten Commandments reads, “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery” (Exod 20:2). Obedience to the following commandments is rooted in gratitude for what God had already done for Israel. How can gratitude lead to a more holy and just life?